indulge in such a struggle; he wanted to avoid it; but, if it became inevitable, it must be undertaken. We could not desert the masses. His point was that the Delhi Pact, which applied to general and political civil disobedience, did not bar this.

I mention this because the charge has been repeatedly brought against the U.P. Provincial Congress Committee and its leaders that they broke the Delhi Pact by re-starting a no-tax campaign. Conveniently for its makers, this charge was brought when those who were charged and could have answered it were all locked up in gaol and every newspaper and press was strictly censored. Quite apart from the fact that the U.P. Committee never started a no-tax campaign in 1931, the point which I wish to make clear is that even such a campaign for an economic purpose, and apart from civil disobedience, would have been no breach of the Delhi Pact. Whether it was justified or not on the merits was another matter; but the peasantry were as much entitled to start it as the workers of a factory are to strike for an economic grievance. This was our position throughout from Delhi to Simla, and it was not only understood but appreciated by the Government.

The agricultural slump of 1929 and onwards came as a climax to a steadily worsening situation. For many years past world agricultural prices had tended to go up, and Indian agriculture, tacked on to the world market, had shared in this tendency. The disproportion in the development of industry and agriculture all over the world had everywhere sent up agricultural prices. As these prices went up in India, the Government revenue and the landlord's rent went up also, so that the actual cultivator hardly profited by this upward tendency. On the whole, the peasantry, except in some favoured areas, deteriorated. In the United Provinces rent went up much faster than revenue, the proportion of relative increase of these two during the first thirty years of this century being nearly (to quote from memory) five to one. Thus while the Government's income from land increased substantially, the landlord's income increased far more, and the tenant remained, as ever, at starvation level. Even where prices fell or there were local natural calamities—drought, floods, locusts, hail, etc.—the rent and revenue remained at the original figures, some remissions being granted very hesitatingly, for the season only. The level of the rents was at the best of times much too high; at other times it became unbearable without recourse to the money-lender. Agricultural debt grew.

All the agricultural classes—landlords, peasant proprietors,